islators from Manipur met Shah in Guwahati and claimed they were under pressure to resign as the community felt betrayed because of non-action against SoO groups. During his three-day visit (May 29-June 1), Shah warned Kuki militant groups of stern action if the SoO terms were violated. On June 12, the CM promised action against "some splinter terrorist groups", alluding to Kuki outfits. But the latest incident in Kangpokpi district in the wee hours of June 14 showed how fraught things still are—villagers made a retaliatory attack on suspected militants holed up in a church, exacting the highest single toll yet of nine dead.

Kuki victims, meanwhile, say they are being targeted by two radical Meitei outfits—Arambai Tenggol and Meitei Leepun. They allege the vigilante groups enjoy the patronage of Meitei politicians of the BJP, including Biren Singh. In fact, Manipur's sole Rajya Sabha member and titular king, Leishemba Sanajaoba, is a founder of Arambai Tenggol. The group not only rejected the allegations but on May 26 temporarily dissolved itself. Meitei Leepun president Pramot Singh, though, has no such qualms. In a Facebook post on April 28, he appealed to his followers to "annihilate our traditional rivals in the hills". "The violence has continued because Meitei groups backed by the state government want to obliterate us," says Seilen Haokip, spokesperson of the KNO.

While rivalry between the valley-dwelling Meiteis and Kukis in the hills has a long history, the immediate trigger was an April 14 high court order—the first acts of violence erupted in a solidarity march opposing it. The court had directed the state to send a recommendation to the Centre to include Meiteis in the Scheduled Tribes (ST) list. The Meitei demand for ST status and the tribals' opposition to it is explained by geography and demographics. Broadly, the state is divided into the Imphal valley and the hill areas. Of Manipur's 60 assembly seats, 40 are in the valley, which has six districts—Imphal East, Imphal West, Thoubal, Bishnupur, Kakching and Kangpokpi. The remaining 20 seats are spread over 10 districts. The valley districts, dominated by mostly Hindu Meiteis, account for just over 11 per cent of the area, but are home to 57 per cent of the state's 2.8 million population (2011 Census). The hill districts, dominated by mostly Christian Naga and Kuki tribes, are home to 43 per cent of the population. On a more granular view, the interim turf—foothills that have been seeing new settlements from both Kukis eager to get closer to the city and Meiteis seeking new living space—forms the real theatre of conflict now, zones of overlap rife with potential for tension.

But perceptually, the geographical binary is strong. The hill tribes claim Meiteis corner developmental works as they enjoy political might; the latter allege they are being increasingly marginalised in their ancestral land. The Meiteis, who comprised 59 per cent of the population in 1951, now make up 44 per cent, as per the 2011 Census. Though they are politically dominant, they are gradually losing their dominance in the administration. "The number of Kukis in the central and state civil services is very high. Many believe the ST quota has made it easy for them to crack competitive exams," says a senior IAS officer.

Another irritant for the Meiteis is the Manipur Land Revenue Act, 1960, which bars non-tribals from the valley from buying hill land. The tribals, though, can buy land in the valley. Because the Act is protected under Article 371C of the Constitution, the state assembly cannot alter this provision without consulting the Hill Areas Committee. "At the

THE CONTEXT

POLITICAL IMBALANCE

- 40 assembly seats are in Imphal valley, dominated by Meiteis
- 10 assembly seats are in hills dominated by Nagas and Kukis

GEOGRAPHICAL IMBALANCE

- Meiteis account for 53 per cent of population but occupy only 10 per cent of the geography
- Nagas and Kukis account for 47 per cent of population but occupy 90 per cent of the geography

RELIGIOUS TENSION

- Between 1961 and 2011, the Hindu population, mostly Meiteis, declined from 62 per cent to 41 per cent, while Christian, Nagas and Kukis jumped from 19 per cent to 41 per cent

DEMOGRAPHIC TENSION

- Between 2001 and 2011, population in Imphal valley, dominated by Meiteis, grew by 16 per cent. Hill areas, inhabited by Nagas and Kukis, grew by 40 per cent



"THE ATTACKS ARE A PRE-PLANNED CONSPIRACY OF KUKI SOO MILITANTS AND MYANMARESE NARCO-TERRORISTS TO TARGET MEITEI AREAS"

LEISHEMBA SANAJAOBA
Rajya Sabha member

"MEITEIS DON'T WANT US TO LIVE WITH THEM. WE NEED A SEPARATE ADMINISTRATION SO THAT WE'RE NOT ATTACKED"



SEILEN HAOKIP
Spokesperson, Kuki National Organisation